Spirituality Is Far from Wahhabism

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَٰنِ الرَّحِيمِ

All praise belongs to Allah, Lord of all worlds. May peace and blessings be upon our beloved Prophet Muhammad ﷺ, his family, his companions, and all who follow his path.

Respected judges, honourable teachers, and my dear brothers and sisters,

Imagine polishing a lamp while leaving its flame unlit. Its surface may shine, but it cannot guide anyone home. The outward forms of worship are precious; their light reaches its fullness when they awaken sincerity, humility, and mercy within us. This inward life is *Ihsan*.

In the Hadith of Jibril, the Prophet ﷺ described *Ihsan*:

أَنْ تَعْبُدَ اللَّهَ كَأَنَّكَ تَرَاهُ، فَإِنْ لَمْ تَكُنْ تَرَاهُ فَإِنَّهُ يَرَاكَ

Meaning: "Worship Allah as if you see Him; if you cannot see Him, He sees you." (Hadith of Jibril, Sahih Muslim 8a, Book 1, Hadith 1)

This awareness turns ordinary moments into worship: a gentle word when anger rises, honesty when no one is watching, and kindness offered without seeking praise.

Allah says in Surah Ash-Shams:

قَدْ أَفْلَحَ مَن زَكَّىٰهَا ۝ وَقَدْ خَابَ مَن دَسَّىٰهَا

"Successful indeed is the one who purifies their soul, and doomed is the one who corrupts it!" (Qur'an, Surah Ash-Shams 91:9–10)

This is *Tazkiyat al-Nafs*: noticing pride before it hardens, envy before it poisons, and heedlessness before it steals the sweetness of worship. The first heart we are asked to examine is our own.

The Sufi scholar Ibn 'Ata' Allah al-Iskandari gives this image of sincerity:

الأَعْمَالُ صُوَرٌ قَائِمَةٌ، وَأَرْوَاحُهَا وُجُودُ سِرِّ الإِخْلَاصِ فِيهَا

"Actions are lifeless forms, but the presence of an inner reality of sincerity within them is what endows them with life-giving Spirit." (Ibn 'Ata' Allah al-Iskandari, *al-Hikam al-'Ata'iyya*, Aphorism 10; Arabic text and Victor Danner's translation)

Sound *Tasawwuf* calls us to live the Shariah with sincerity, discipline, and love. The heart is a mirror: remembrance clears its dust, repentance restores its brightness, and service lets its light fall on others.

History gives this teaching a human face. In *Deliverance from Error*, Imam al-Ghazali recounts leaving Baghdad during a spiritual crisis; his withdrawal from public teaching lasted eleven years. He closes with a prayer:

فَأَسْأَلُهُ أَنْ يُصْلِحَنِي أَوَّلًا، ثُمَّ يُصْلِحَ بِي

“I ask Him first of all to reform me and then to reform through me.” (Abu Hamid al-Ghazali, *Deliverance from Error*, concluding section; Arabic text · W. Montgomery Watt’s English translation)

What humility: before asking to change the world, ask Allah to begin with the heart.

So when I say, “Spirituality Is Far from Wahhabism,” I speak of any religious outlook that makes outward conformity the whole of faith and leaves too little room for the inward journey. This title is not a judgment on the sincerity of people who bear a label; only Allah knows each heart. Muslims may disagree sincerely about particular practices. We can hold our convictions, study carefully, and still guard one another’s dignity.

The Prophet ﷺ taught:

إِنَّ اللَّهَ لَا يَنْظُرُ إِلَى صُوَرِكُمْ وَأَمْوَالِكُمْ وَلَكِنْ يَنْظُرُ إِلَى قُلُوبِكُمْ وَأَعْمَالِكُمْ

“Verily Allah does not look to your faces and your wealth but He looks to your heart and to your deeds.” (Sahih Muslim 2564c, Book 45, Hadith 42)

After prayer, does our family receive more patience? After learning, do our neighbours receive more kindness? Does our love for the Messenger ﷺ appear in the mercy we show to people?

> “The quality of mercy is not strained.
> It droppeth as the gentle rain from heaven
> Upon the place beneath.” (William Shakespeare, *The Merchant of Venice*, Act 4, Scene 1, lines 190–193)

Let knowledge make the heart more kind,
Let worship leave no pride behind.
Let love be seen in what we do,
And mercy shine in all we pursue.

Thus, worship and character become one prayer: a heart turned to Allah and hands made gentle toward His creation.

May Allah purify our hearts, grant us beneficial knowledge and sincere worship, fill us with love for His beloved Messenger ﷺ, and make our character a comfort to those around us. May He unite us upon goodness and teach us to disagree without hatred.

Thank you. **Assalamu Alaikum wa Rahmatullahi wa Barakatuh.**